

Debate

Teaching with AI (TAI)

Mirte van der Eyden[1], Andrea López Incera[2]

[1] Institut für Fachdidaktik, Universität Innsbruck
mirte.van-der-eyden@uibk.ac.at

[2] Departament de didàctica de la matemàtica i les ciències experimentals, Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona
andrea.lopez.incera@uab.cat













Project funded by Erasmus+ Programme of the European Union

Subject: Debate about AI
Activity duration: 180 min

Steps:

1. Distribute debate themes and prepare in groups (90 min)
2. Debate in groups (90 min)

Learning goals:

- Doing research about an ethical topic
- Preparing arguments
- Debate

Debate

on ethics and practical consequences of AI

Here we share a list of suggested topics for a debate about AI. Students get assigned a thesis and a side (for/against) in groups of 2 or 3. They get time to do research and prepare their arguments. Then, they will have a debate with the other side. The students in de audience each prepare a question. Afterwards, two students in the audience are appointed to ask a question.

Debate Topics on AI

Each topic has a short thesis, a simple explanation, and two sides (For / Against). Students argue for or against the thesis.

1. **Thesis: AI-made works should be allowed to have copyright.**
   What this means: If a human uses AI to make images, music, or text, can that human own the rights like an author?
   For:

   - The human still makes choices: prompts, edits, and selection show creativity.
   - It motivates people to invest time and money in creative AI.
   - Tools have always changed art (like cameras); authorship can include new tools.

   Against:

   - Copyright is for human authors; fully machine-made work should not qualify.
   - Could create a flood of protected machine content and legal problems.
   - Other options (contracts, licenses) may fit better than copyright.

2. **Thesis: The environmental cost of generative AI is bigger than its benefits.**
   What this means: Training and using big AI models uses a lot of electricity and water. Is it worth it?
   For:

   - Data centers use much energy and water; local communities pay the price.
   - Many AI uses are low-value or replace simpler methods.
   - The same resources could support health, climate, or public services.

   Against:

   - AI can save energy in other areas (smart grids, transport, buildings).
   - Chips and data centers are getting more efficient.
   - Rules and clean energy can reduce the harm without stopping progress.

3. **Thesis: AI companions and creative tools are good for mental health.**
   What this means: Chatbots and AI art/music tools might help people feel better.
   For:

   - Easy to access, no stigma; good for journaling and reflection.
   - Can reduce loneliness and support coping skills.
   - Early studies show mood benefits when used with care.

   Against:

   - People may become dependent and talk less to real friends.
   - Bots can give wrong or unsafe advice.
   - Privacy risks: sensitive data could be misused.

4. **Thesis: Students should be allowed to use generative AI in arts and humanities assignments.**
   What this means: Can students use tools like chatbots or image generators for class work?
   For:

   - Matches real creative work today; teaches how to guide and improve AI output.
   - Helps with brainstorming and feedback for all students.
   - With clear rules and citation, it supports learning.

   Against:

   - Makes it hard to judge a student's own skills.
   - Tempts students to shortcut and weakens basics (writing, analysis, technique).
   - Not all students have equal access; tools can be biased.

5. **Thesis: Using public internet content to train AI is fair use.**
   What this means: Is it okay for companies to scrape online text and images to train AI without asking each creator?
   For:

   - The training is transformative (learning patterns, not copying exact works).
   - Needed for useful AI; similar to text and data mining.
   - Society benefits from better tools and knowledge.

   Against:

   - It takes creators' work without permission or pay.
   - AI outputs can replace the original creators' market.
   - Publicly available does not mean free to use; privacy and website rules matter.

6. **Thesis: AI-made art is art.**
   What this means: Should works made with or by AI be accepted as "art"?
   For:

- Art depends on intention, context, and audience—not only on the tool.
- Humans still choose prompts, curate results, and set meaning.
- Art history shows new media (photo, video, code) become accepted.

Against:

- AI lacks human feeling and agency inside the work.
- Often imitates styles; may lead to sameness and pastiche.
- Can shift focus from human craft to automation.

7. **Thesis: Teachers should use AI to make teaching materials and help evaluate students.**
   What this means: Is it good for teachers to use AI to prepare lessons, quizzes, and feedback?
   For:

   - Saves time so teachers can focus on students.
   - Helps personalize learning and improve accessibility.
   - Can support clear rubrics and spot learning gaps.

   Against:

   - AI can be biased or wrong; grading may become less fair or clear.
   - Risks to student privacy and data security.
   - Could weaken teacher skills and relationships with students.

8. **Thesis: In creative and cultural jobs, AI will cause more job losses than new jobs.**
   What this means: Will AI take away more jobs (designers, writers, translators, etc.) than it creates?
   For:

   - Fast replacement in illustration, content writing, and post-production.
   - Lower pay and fewer entry-level opportunities.
   - Big tech firms capture most value, not individual creators.

   Against:

   - New jobs appear (model trainers, prompt experts, curators, verifiers).
   - Higher productivity can grow markets and demand.
   - History shows tech changes jobs more than it removes them over time.

9. **Thesis: People must say when they used AI in academic or creative work.**
   What this means: Should students, writers, and artists disclose AI help in their work?
   For:

- Builds trust and protects academic honesty.
- Gives proper credit and shows the human's real contribution.
- Helps with copyright, safety checks, and provenance.

Against:

- Hard to enforce when AI is built into many tools.
- Might discourage experimentation with useful tools.
- Some say the result matters more than which tool was used.

Optional tips for students

- Define key words at the start in 1–2 simple sentences (e.g., copyright," fair use," "disclosure").
- Use clear examples: a news article on AI energy use, a school policy, a court case, a real artist's experience.
- Agree on team roles: one introduces, one gives evidence, one rebuts and closes.

© 2026 “Teaching in AI” (TAI) Consortium.

This educational material was developed within the framework of the Erasmus+ project “Teaching in AI” (TAI) (2025-1-DK01-KA226-SCH-000365972).

Funded by the European Union.

The views and opinions expressed are those of the author(s) only and do not necessarily reflect those of the European Union or the granting authority. Neither the European Union nor the granting authority can be held responsible for them.

This material is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International Licence (CC BY 4.0), unless otherwise indicated.